

KLAUS AND EFFECT

Klaus Bartonietz might be one of the **most recognised** foreign coaches across sports in India, but his fame is majorly due to his six-year tenure as coach of Neeraj Chopra.

Jonathan Selvaraj
jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Himanshu Jakhar might be the reigning Asian U-18 javelin champion and one of India's best prospects in the sport, but on a blistering evening at Hisar's Agricultural University last month, he was discovering just how much there is still left for him to learn.

To the average observer, the 17-year-old's throws seem fine — landing in the 70m range with smooth trajectories. But for Himanshu, the approval he craves for must come from a figure standing just off the runway — a septuagenarian in a baseball cap who is video-recording his throws on

an iPad. When he doesn't get the thumbs-up he is hoping for, Himanshu studies the footage to check where he went wrong. This time, it looks like his left leg is bending too much as it blocks, costing him crucial energy.

Rather than be discouraged, Himanshu makes over a dozen more throws over the course of the evening, with the belief that he could do better. **It's clear why he wants this man's approval — it's not every day that Dr Klaus Bartonietz (with Neeraj Chopra, above) comes over to critique his throws.** By the end of the session, Himanshu is all smiles.

Klaus may have written many of the textbooks on javelin throw, but his fame as one of the most recognised foreign coaches across sports in India is majorly due to his

six-year tenure as coach of Neeraj Chopra. Together they created history by winning gold at the Tokyo Olympics, followed by silver at the 2022 World Championships, gold at the 2023 Worlds, and finally silver at the 2024 Olympics in Paris.

Klaus concluded his six-year partnership with the Indian not long after the Paris Games, but last month he was back in India. Although in the country only for a week on his most recent trip, he plans to return more frequently in the months to come.

The biomechanics expert will be creating training plans, conducting online classes for coaches, and mentoring younger athletes including Himanshu, Deepika (a silver medallist at the 2022 Asian Under-18 Championship), and Jyoti (a



K. R. DEEPAK